

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week One: Lesson Three



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Overview



- Analysing essay questions
- Choosing an essay question

When preparing a response to an essay question, you need to consider the following:



What do you have to do?

- a) Take a position in an academic debate? Do you agree/disagree with a view expressed in the question, or is the question too complex to take one side over another?

The main point is to express your opinion.

- b) Suggest solutions to a problem?
- c) Evaluate the effectiveness/validity of a policy, model, theory...?
- d) Identify the causes of a situation?
- e) Other? If so what?

How many parts are there to the question? Are these of equal importance? Use the structure of the question to structure your own response

Are there any restrictions on the topic? (i.e. time/place/perspective)
If there aren't any, then you should provide these

What terms need defining? Very basic terms don't need defining, but any term that is open to interpretation/ contestation does need to be defined or explained

How to analyse a question



Question

Structure

Restriction

Definition

Most **successful nationalisms** in the 20th century are beneficiaries of imperial collapse'. **Discuss** with reference to EITHER **Europe after 1918** OR **European decolonisation** after 1945 OR the **breakup of the Soviet Union** after 1989.

***'Discuss'** and **'Critically discuss'** both mean provide your own opinion with justification drawn from academic research and/or real world examples (preferably those cited in academic literature)*

No clear structure suggested by question, so you have to provide it.

Question

Structure

Restriction

Definition

Is citizen participation democratising? If so, why? If not, why not?
(SO407 Politics and Society)

More open question – no restriction, no suggestion of structure, so you need to provide these. Question suggests a yes/no response, but you don't have to adopt one position. Different contexts may provide different answers.

Question

Structure

Restriction

Definition

Discuss critically the strengths and weaknesses of **'Anti-Globalisation'** arguments in respect of:

- International capital flows, and
- Personal income inequality. (MG412 Globalisation and Strategy)

A possible structure is clearly suggested by the question:

Define 'Anti-globalisation arguments'

Identify strengths & weaknesses of these arguments in terms of international capital flows

Identify strengths & weaknesses of these arguments in terms of personal income equality

What makes a good assignment question for LN905



Feasibility – it's a good idea to choose a topic that you already have some knowledge of. In addition, the topic should not be too general or broad in scope. At the same time, it should not be too technical or detailed.

Interest – you will spend quite a lot of time working on your assignment, so it should be a topic that really interests you

Relevance – it should be a topic that is relevant to your chosen field of study and that is part of the current debate within your subject area

Availability – it should be a topic that has already been researched so you can access sufficient research material from books and articles

Point to consider when choosing your assignment questions



If using examples or a case study, remember these are generally used to illustrate a broader point. You may choose examples from your own country, but you should not focus on these too much.

Question 1 — Too specific:

To what extent did Elon Musk's reinstatement of banned accounts on Twitter in late 2022 increase measurable rates of hate speech on the platform?

Question 2 — Broader:

How do platform ownership structures shape content moderation decisions, and what are the implications for democratic discourse?

In question 2, you might use the Musk example to illustrate your answer, but you also need to focus on recent research into ownership structures

Too descriptive The question should invite analysis more than summary.

Weak: *"Describe the causes of the 2008 financial crisis."*

Strong: Critically evaluate the extent to which structural factors, rather than individual behaviour, explain patterns of wealth accumulation in post-2008 Western economies.

Too broad It offers no analytical focus and cannot be answered meaningfully in a single essay.

Weak: *"Discuss inequality."*

Strong: To what extent does intersectionality as a theoretical framework advance understanding of labour market inequality in contemporary urban contexts?

Ambiguous or poorly worded Vague terms make it unclear what is being asked.

Weak: *"Consider the role of culture in society."*

Strong: Analyse the role of national cultural identity in shaping public trust in political institutions, drawing on comparative evidence from at least two societies.

Requires only knowledge recall It tests memory rather than higher-order thinking.

Weak: *"What are Giddens' key theoretical concepts?"*

Strong: To what extent does Giddens' theory of structuration offer a useful framework for analysing the reproduction of social inequality in digital environments?